America Poem

By S.A. Griffin

INTRODUCTION

Imagine a slide show of images . . . images that capture America in all its glory and all its shame. A slide show of images . . . dependent on the viewer to assign value to each image, to catalog and to judge America from various perspectives. This is what S.A. Griffin has achieved but not with visual images . . . this poet takes the challenge one step further and paints his pictures with words. So, sit back, open your mind, your imagination and your memory of what is America and how it has changed since the turn of the century.

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(Pg 573-575) it was the pledge of allegiance

everyday

to the flag

it was the pledge of allegiance

it was our country 'tis of thee

New Yorkers that never saw a cow

cows that never saw a city

mothers fathers sons and daughters

the born and unborn

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it was a house that was always there

like wood and brick eternity

it was gold silver oil

it was t.v. that was American

it was "made in the U.S.A."

it was small towns that was somewhere else

big cities that was everywhere else

that was somewhere

it was a wheel

it was wheels

it was the Wizard of Oz white man ethic that

snuck into grandma's womb and exploded like

Pandora's box over the rising sun

all hail the glory that was God!

it was deliverance

lovers and lies that were promises

birds piloting over silent streams of sky

it was dreams and dreaming

and it was flying higher than God

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it was faith
pure and uncut
it was spent cartridges that hammered our dreams
fast to reality
it was Monroe
Garbo
Harpo
Chico
Groucho
Presley
Gone With The Wind
The Babe and baseball
hearts filled with hotdogs and homeruns
jazz pouring out of speakeasies like
hot pepper sauce over flat tongues
F.D.R.
J.F.K.
Gary Cooper and High Noon
Hank Williams
Pete Seeger
Huddie Ledbetter and

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America
was an eager young debutante
in soft white and pink crinoline and taffeta dresses
and waves of waterfall tresses
in love with
storybook princes and princesses

it was
"*I have been to the mountaintop*"
assassinations and angry black clouds of riot

it was the coming of age of Harlow and Hitler
and the bastardization of Nietzche by
Hitler and Hollywood
blonde breasts sagging into fading hairlines
it was desperate to be un-understood leaders
who wanted to follow

it was a generation of giants and giantesses
spawned by chrome gods and goddesses
in the backfields of glorious houses
Chevys
Fords

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Mercurys
Oldsmobiles
Chryslers and
Buicks that longed to become Cadillacs

it was men who hated men
pathetic pawns of power
begging for manhood
borne of paper
thrusting accusations of
"*communist, red f*gg*t, n***, wop, spic, kike, white trash, whore*"

it was a time
it is a time
it is America

it is a can opener
a microwave
a long distance telephone call
satellite Jesus crucified by capitalist commanders
hip new fads of neon nostalgia
sitcoms t.v. dinners
used used cars

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fast fast cars
55 miles per hour
fast fast food
and the killing that rages unresolved in the
french fried inside and outside

the headlines
the hairlines
the waistlines

it is the dead inside of a quarter pounder with cheese
and the sesame seeds of love that
should have

it is valleys of vines
plains of corn and wheat and dyed red meat
cut picture perfect
estrogen fed chickens with centerfold breasts
it is a single stalk of corn
growing out of a crack in the sidewalk
on a Hollywood street corner
it is forty years of fallout
and four hundred more

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it is the one that got away

the soulmate

perfect one

it is the perfection of imperfection

and the searching for truth

it is the heartland

it is America

it is the great love and admiration

the stifling addled ambition

it is the people and the truth

which is somewhere searching in a

rambling car that only stops for

dollar gas

hot coffee

then races off again over the stoic face of

what is

America

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: S.A. Griffin
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AWARD HISTORY

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